in which Tihar was metamorphosing from a hellhole of a prison into an ashram, her superiors were watching the increased wattage of the spotlight that was focusing on her. All the effort that was being put into the overhauling of the rusted Tihar machinery and in making directional changes in the focus of such effort were perfunctorily summed up as being so much effort to merely hog publicity.

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Tihar, on an average, contains about 150 to 200 foreign inmates at any given time. A short time before Kiran became the IG (Prisons) in May 1993, there had been a newspaper report emanating from the USA that highlighted the miserable plight of these prisoners. Indian groups working on issues of human rights, like the PUDR and the PUCL (People's Union for Democratic Rights and People's Union for Civil Liberties), took up this issue and a hullabaloo was raised about it.

The various foreign embassies and high commissions had also taken up the cause of the prisoners from their countries with the Government of India. This persistent foreign concern was part of the legacy of Tihar inherited by its new IG. A short while later, though, when effective changes had commenced to take place, these very inmates mentioned these changes through word of mouth. This galvanized the foreign press and media to seek to record for their viewers the changing scenario and probably bring some relief to the unfortunate families of the prisoners.

Kiran had all along believed in accessible and transparent functioning. She had also all along in her career encouraged participatory management, from both within the staff and the community at large. The media was a part of the same community. In the case of the prison, it had a special role of working as a bridge between the closed walls and the apprehensive society. Tihar had been and is always in the news – so what kind of news was the media going to get now? Steal in or manage to get into the jail somehow or see for themselves? Kiran decided on the last option. She had the power under the prison rules to allow visitors 'duly conducted'. Instead of 'briefings', whoever expressed a genuine concern for the prisoners was allowed inside with cameras. They could come in, talk to prisoners, see the progress, discuss matters with officials and write on their own. Their own reporting enabled objectivity with conviction. Such reporting also put in perspective matters such as (a) delayed trials, (b) overcrowding, (c) the misuse of TADA, (d) the agony behind dowry offences, (e) the condition of women prisoners and (f) neglect of prison staff. On the positive side the media could project what participative community support could do to turn a jail around and make it an ashram.

During her tenure Kiran had some noteworthy visitors from a cross-section of society, namely: Khushwant Singh (eminent writer and journalist), Amrita Pritam (poetess and writer), Rajmohan Gandhi (the grandson of Mahatma Gandhi), Dr Lee Brown (an American official concerned with drug policy in the USA), Mrs Frank Wisner (wife of the American ambassador to India), V. N. Narayanan (editor, *The Hindustan Times*), Anup Jalota (composer and singer), Naseeruddin Shah (actor), Manoj Prabhakar (cricketer), and Dr Charles W. Colson of the Prison Fellowship, USA.

Among the Central Government dignitaries, the visitors included Salman Khurshid (minister of state for external affairs), Sita Ram Kesri (welfare minister), Arjun Singh (former minister for human resources development) and Mukul Wasnik (deputy minister for sports).

The Delhi state officials included the lieutenant governor (P. K. Dave), the chief minister (Madan Lal Khurana), the health minister (Dr Harsh Vardhan) and the minister of education (Sahib Singh Verma).

Members of the Human Rights Commission, such as Fatima Bibi, also visited Tihar.

Spiritual leaders (and intellectuals) belonging to groups such as ISKCON, Brahmakumaris, OSHO,